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Credit - Drishti Ias

India’s Post-LWE Transformation

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Source: TH

Why in News?

On **31 st March 2026** , the **Union Home Minister** announced that **India is now free from Maoist insurgency ,** marking a major shift from its status as the most serious internal security threat in 2009–10.

- The development signals a transition from conflict to stability, with the focus now moving towards inclusive governance and **long-term development in former Left Wing Extremism (LWE)** affected regions.

What is the Significance of India’s Transition from LWE to Relative Peace?

- **Strategic & Internal Security Impact:**
  - **Reclamation of State Sovereignty:** The most immediate impact is the restoration of the **state's monopoly on the use of force.**
    - The "liberated zones" managed by Maoist parallel governments (Janatana Sarkars) are dismantled, restoring constitutional jurisdiction.
    - It provides the operational space to fulfill the foundational mandates of the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules,** transforming the state's perception from an "exploitative sovereign" to a "welfare facilitator."
  - **Redeployment of Central Forces:** For decades, over 100 battalions of **Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs)** were locked into internal counter-insurgency grids.
    - The neutralization of the LWE threat allows the state to re-calibrate and potentially redeploy these specialized forces to secure volatile **international borders or other emerging internal security theaters** .
- **Economic Unlocking & Resource Integration:**
  - **Reversing the Resource Curse:** LWE-affected regions like Bastar (Chhattisgarh) and Saranda (Jharkhand) hold some of India’s most **critical mineral reserves** (iron ore, coal, bauxite) can attract greater investment with the restoration of peace, improving infrastructure and integrating these areas into the **mainstream economy while significantly reducing security risks and costs for both public and private players.**

- **Integration of the Regional Economy:** Sustained peace enables the transition from a localized, subsistence forest economy to an integrated market economy.
- **Capitalizing on Minor Forest Produce (MFP):** Without the extortion tax (Maoist levy), the state can formalize the procurement of **MFP at Minimum Support Prices (MSP),** directly transferring wealth to tribal households and setting the stage for local agro-processing MSMEs.

- **Socio-Political & Constitutional Impact:**
  - **Deepening of Democracy:** The transition moves the paradigm from the **"bullet to the ballot."**
    - Increased voter turnouts in erstwhile hyper-sensitive booths signify the **reintegration of the Adivasi population into the democratic mainstream** , legitimizing the electoral process.
  - **Restoration of Civil Rights:** The end of insurgency removes the dual threat faced by local populations **security operations on one side and Maoist kangaroo courts (Jan Adalats)** on the other.
    - It paves the way for the assertion of genuine constitutional rights, particularly under the **Forest Right Act (FRA), 2006.**
  - **Social & Developmental:** Peaceful corridors allow for the resumption of democratic processes, the establishment of **Eklavya Model Residential Schools (EMRS) ,** and the execution of tribal youth upskilling programs (e.g., ***Roshni* Scheme**).

Click here to Read: Left Wing Extremism-Free India

What are the Key Challenges in the Post-LWE Phase?

- **Administrative Vacuum:** The transition from security-led “area domination” to routine governance remains weak, as civil servants, teachers, and doctors are reluctant to serve in remote, conflict-affected areas.
  - Poor implementation of **Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act, 1996** further limits real self-governance for tribal communities.
- **The "De-risking" Paradox:** Insurgency acted as a **violent deterrent to corporate mining.**
  - The return of "peace" de-risks capital, leading to a rapid influx of extractive industries into mineral-rich tribal belts.
  - This may accelerate the displacement of **Adivasi communities** , replicating the exact conditions of state-sponsored alienation that gave birth to the **Maoist movement.**
- **Bureaucratic Subversion of the FRA:** The FRA, 2006, is the primary economic shield for forest dwellers.
  - However, the bureaucratic rejection rates for **Community Forest Rights (CFR)** claims remain

staggeringly high.
    - The structural challenge is that the **state continues to view forests as sovereign revenue generators** rather than community-owned economic assets.
- **Criminalization of the Vacuum:** The collapse of the ideological Maoist leadership does not destroy this lucrative grey economy.
    - Instead, it creates an unregulated vacuum that is rapidly being **co-opted by apolitical organized crime syndicates,** timber mafias, and localized cartels.
    - Preventing the post-insurgency vacuum from being exploited by organized crime, ensuring that political insurgency does not **evolve into decentralized cartel-based violence.**
- **Judicial Choke-points:** Thousands of tribal youths remain incarcerated in district jails under stringent laws like the **Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act 1967 ,** often lacking trial dates.
    - The judicial apparatus in these remote districts is entirely unequipped to process this post-conflict caseload.
    - This legal bottleneck creates a permanent class of disenfranchised, deeply resentful youth, maintaining a fertile ground for future radicalization.

What Measures can Ensure a Successful Post-LWE Transformation?

AIEEEE Framework

- **Measure:** Implement a region-specific, outcome-linked transformation plan jointly executed by the Centre and States.
    - Use the **AIEEEE framework (Accountability, Innovation, Evidence, Equity, Empathy, and Efficiency)** to drive the convergence of existing schemes for effective delivery, avoiding mere policy proliferation.
- **Empirical Case Study: Dantewada (Chhattisgarh)**
    - **Application:** The district dismantled siloed funding by pooling state **District Mineral Foundation (DMF)** and central **Aspirational Districts Programme (ADP) funds.**
        - They utilized real-time mobile data for targeted health interventions, fast-tracked **Community Forest Rights (CFR)** for equity, and built "Education Hubs" to replace the optics of a military occupation with empathetic governance.
    - **The Impact:** By forcing structural convergence, the administration transitioned from episodic counter-insurgency to predictable, data-driven, and rights-affirming governance.
        - Accountability was successfully tied to verifiable human development outcomes (like reduced **maternal mortality**) rather than mere financial expenditure.

Strict Adherence to PESA & The Forest Rights Act

- **Measure:** The state must move beyond granting basic land titles. As recommended by the **Virginius Xaxa Committee (2014)** , true tribal empowerment requires conferring qualitative ownership of **Minor Forest Produce (MFP)** and making the **Gram Sabha the absolute foundational unit of local governance under the PESA Act, 1996.**
- **Empirical Case Study: The Bastar Procurement Model (Chhattisgarh)**
    - **Application:** Bastar shifted from an extractive state monopoly to decentralized wealth creation.

    - The state government aggressively raised the MSP for critical forest produce like ***tendu* leaves** and *mahua* .
    - More importantly, it established **Van Dhan Vikas Kendras,** empowering local **Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Gram Sabhas to procure and process this produce locally.**
  - **The Impact:** By legally recognizing the Gram Sabha's economic mandate over MFP, the state directly transferred capital into the tribal household.
    - This structural shift broke the local population's economic reliance on the **Maoist "grey economy" and effectively bankrupted the insurgent levy (extortion) networks.**

Development-Security Synergy

- **Measure:** Deep integration of the **Aspirational Districts Programme (ADP)** with post-LWE stabilisation, combined with tribal-focused missions like **PM-JANMAN** and **DAJUGA** can effectively close governance gaps.
  - Simultaneously, capacity-building initiatives like **Adi Karmayogi** can strengthen field-level administration and improve last-mile delivery at the panchayat level.
- **Empirical Case Study: The 'SETU' Framework in Swabhiman Anchal (Malkangiri, Odisha)**
  - **Application:** For decades, the 151 villages of Malkangiri’s "Cut-off Area" were a sovereign Maoist safe haven due to geographical isolation.
    - The turning point was not just the construction of the **Gurupriya Bridge (kinetic security),** but the immediate, synchronized launch of the **SETU (Socio-Economic Transformation and Upliftment) initiative.**
  - **The Impact:** The state treated security dominance merely as a conduit for development saturation.
    - **USOF-funded** mobile towers, bus routes, and primary health centers were rushed across the bridge.
    - By tracking real-time delivery metrics rather than just budget allocations, the state rapidly dismantled the ideological isolation of the region, proving that **infrastructure is the most lethal anti-insurgency weapon.**

Transition to SMART Policing

- **Measure:** A credible state must ensure **humane policing, timely justice, and effective grievance redressal** .
  - Fast-tracking undertrial cases, especially for SC/ST communities, and expanding legal aid are essential to rebuild faith in the justice system.
  - Gradually transition CAPFs out of civil domains. Rely on specialized, locally recruited, and culturally integrated state police forces for residual intelligence gathering and maintaining local trust.
  - Develop the **"Police-Station-as-a-Growth-Center"** model, where the local police station acts as a facilitator for grievance redressal and welfare delivery, not just an enforcement unit.
- **Empirical Case Study: The State-Led Neutralization Grid (Andhra Pradesh & Telangana)**
  - **Application:** Instead of relying indefinitely on massive deployments of CAPF battalions, the state institutionalized its own highly specialized apparatus: the Greyhounds for precise tactical operations, and the State Intelligence Branch (SIB) for information dominance.
  - **The Impact:** This model proved that a **small, locally recruited force** fluent in the regional dialect, topography, and tribal culture is vastly superior to large, alienated central forces.
    - As the kinetic threat was neutralized by the Greyhounds, standard civil policing was able to **resume**

seamlessly, focusing on civic action programs and rebuilding community trust without the optics of a military occupation.

Conclusion

The final phase of India's LWE transition is both **psychological and administrative** , requiring sustained trust-building and inclusive governance. Moving from counter-insurgency to **cooperative, development-led transformation** will ensure these regions evolve from conflict zones into integral engines of national growth.

Drishti Mains Question:

"The end of Left Wing Extremism marks not an end, but a transition to governance challenges." Critically examine.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the significance of India being declared free from LWE?
It marks restoration of state authority, decline of insurgency, and shift towards governance-led development in tribal regions.

2. How does the Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006 help in LWE areas?
It grants land and community forest rights, addressing tribal alienation and reducing insurgent recruitment.

3. What is the role of PESA Act, 1996 in post-LWE governance?
It empowers Gram Sabhas in Scheduled Areas, ensuring local self-governance and tribal participation.

4. What is the Aspirational Districts Programme (ADP)?
A NITI Aayog initiative targeting backward districts to improve health, education, and infrastructure outcomes.

5. What is the AIEEEE framework in post-LWE transformation?
It focuses on Accountability, Innovation, Evidence, Equity, Empathy, and Efficiency for effective governance delivery.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/8Kzk2tQUUYY**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Mains

Q. What are the determinants of left-wing extremism in the Eastern part of India? What Strategy should the Government of India, civil administration and security forces adopt to counter the threat in the affected areas? **(2020)**

Q. The persisting drives of the government for development of large industries in backward areas have resulted in isolating the tribal population and the farmers who face multiple displacements. With Malkangiri and Naxalbari foci, discuss the corrective strategies needed to win the Left Wing Extremism (LWE) doctrine that affected citizens back into the mainstream of social and economic growth. **(2015)**

Shekha Jheel Bird Sanctuary as India’s 99th Ramsar Site

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Source: PIB

The Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change has designated **Shekha Jheel Bird Sanctuary in Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh,** as a Ramsar site (Wetland of International Importance), taking **India’s total Ramsar sites to 99 and the State’s tally to 12.**

- **Origin:** It is a 25-hectare **freshwater perennial wetland** that came into existence in 1852 following the construction of the **Upper Ganga Canal** , which divides the lake into two parts.
- **Ecological Significance:** The wetland acts as a crucial wintering habitat for over **166 water bird species** , including important species like the **painted stork and bar-headed goose** , alongside mammalian fauna such as the **blackbuck** (a Schedule I species) and blue bull.
- **Flora & Vegetation:** The dominant tree species include *Terminalia arjuna* and *Syzygium cumini* , but the native ecosystem is increasingly threatened by **invasive alien species** such as ***Lantana camara* , *Parthenium hysterophorus* , and Water Hyacinth** .
- **Anthropogenic Threats:** The wetland is degrading due to **siltation** (caused by unscientific mound construction in 1991), loss of forest cover due to land distribution schemes, and increased **poaching vulnerabilities** facilitated by nearby road construction.
  - Additionally, aggressive water chestnut farming has reduced the foraging surface area for migratory birds.
- **Eutrophication:** The profuse and uncontrolled growth of **water hyacinth** is causing severe **eutrophication** , deteriorating the water body's health and reducing habitats for waterfowl.

Read more: **India Expands Ramsar Network to 98 Sites**

1st Structured Pulse Procurement in Bihar

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Source: PIB

The Government of India has strengthened Minimum Support Price(**MSP)-based procurement** under **PM-AASHA** , expanding operations in Chhattisgarh and **launching Bihar's first structured pulse procurement initiative** under the **Atmanirbhar Pulses Mission** to support farmers and enhance self-reliance.

- **Bihar Pulse Procurement Initiative:** Organised procurement of masoor (lentil) initiated in Bihar led by the **National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India Limited (NCCF)** , with the **National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Limited (NAFED)** preparing to scale operations under the Price Support Scheme through its cooperative network.
- **Chhattisgarh MSP Procurement:** Procurement is driven by the NCCF, utilising the **E-Samyukti digital platform** and **PACS** centres across multiple districts, with a focus on crops like **chana** and **masoor** and large-scale farmer participation.

Atmanirbhar Pulses Mission

- **About:** Announced in the **Union Budget 2025–26** , the Mission f **or Aatmanirbharta in Pulses** was launched in October 2025. It is a **centrally sponsored scheme** aimed at achieving **self-sufficiency in pulses** over **2025–26 to 2030–31** .
- **Focus Crops:** The mission places specific emphasis on **Tur (Arhar), Urad, and Masoor** , which are critical for daily consumption but currently face production gaps.
- **Key Objectives:** It focuses on **reducing imports, improving yields,** promoting climate-resilient practices, enhancing farmers' incomes, and ensuring long-term nutritional security.

PM-AASHA (Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay Sanrakshan Abhiyan)

- **About:** Launched in **2018** to ensure **effective implementation of Minimum Support Price (MSP)** and protect farmers from price volatility.
- **Objective:** The scheme aims to ensure **remunerative prices, reduce distress sales, and strengthen agricultural income stability** , particularly for pulses and oilseed farmers.
- **Components:** It provides a **comprehensive price support framework** through three components:
  - **Price Support Scheme (PSS)** for physical procurement of pulses, oilseeds, and copra
  - **Price Deficiency Payment Scheme (PDPS)** to compensate farmers when market prices fall below MSP
  - **Private Procurement & Stockist Scheme (PPSS)** to involve private players in procurement

Read More: **Achieving Self-Sufficiency in Pulses**

SEED Scheme for DNT Communities

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Source: PIB

Recently, the **Development and Welfare Board for De-notified, Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic Communities (DWBDNC)** reported significant progress under the **SEED Scheme during FY 2025–26** , highlighting enhanced outreach and impact.

About SEED Scheme

- **About:** It is a **central sector scheme launched in February 2022** by the **Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment** for **economic empowerment of DNT, NT and SNT communities** .

- The scheme has an **outlay of ₹200 crore over five years (from 2021–22)** and is implemented by **DWBDNC** through an **online portal for registration and monitoring** .

- **Components** : It focuses on **four major components** :
  - **Free coaching** for competitive exams and professional courses
  - **Health insurance coverage** through PMJAY
  - **Livelihood support** for income generation
  - **Housing assistance** through schemes like PMAY

About DNT, NT and SNT Communities

- **About:** The term **De-notified Tribes** refers to communities that were once classified under the **Criminal Tribes Acts,1871** which were implemented by the British Government.
  - The Acts were abolished by the **Government of India in 1952** , leading to the **De-Notification** of these communities.
  - A few of these communities which were listed as **de-notified were also nomadic** .
    - **Nomadic and semi-nomadic** communities are defined as those who **move from one place to another** rather than living in one place all the time.
  - While most DNTs are spread across the **SC** **,** **ST** and **OBC** categories, some DNTs are not covered in any of the SC, ST or OBC categories.
- **Distribution:** India has around **150 Denotified Tribes and ~500 Nomadic communities** , accounting for **nearly 10% of the population** .
- **Challenges:** Various committees (e.g., **Kaka Kalelkar Commission** **,** **Mandal Commission** **, NCRWC**) have highlighted their **historical marginalisation, stigma and need for targeted welfare measures** .

> **Read more:** **Scheme for Economic Empowerment of DNTs**

India–Egypt Defence Cooperation

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Source: TH

India and Egypt held the **11th Joint Defence Committee meeting in Cairo** to strengthen bilateral defence cooperation and outline a roadmap for future engagement.

- **Defence Cooperation Roadmap (2026–27):** Both sides agreed on a forward-looking plan focusing on **expanding structured military interactions, intensifying joint training, enhancing maritime security cooperation** , and increasing the scope and complexity of military exercises.
- **Defence Industry Collaboration** : India highlighted its defence manufacturing growth, with production exceeding $20 billion and exports of around $4 billion to over 100 countries. Both sides explored opportunities for co-development and co-production.
- **Maritime and Air Force Cooperation:** First-ever Navy-to-Navy staff talks held; India highlighted the role of its Navy in ensuring freedom of navigation in the Indian Ocean Region and the contribution of the Information Fusion Centre .
  - The Indian delegation also engaged with the Egyptian Air Force leadership to strengthen **air force cooperation** .
- **Historical and Strategic Context:** India–Egypt defence ties are anchored in the **2022 MoU on defence cooperation** and were further strengthened by elevating relations to a **Strategic Partnership in 2023** , reflecting deepening strategic alignment.
  - The Indian delegation's tribute at the **Heliopolis War Memorial** highlights shared historical connections and longstanding goodwill between the two countries.

Read More: **Reinvigorating India-Africa Partnership**

Rail Link to Bauxite Hills in Odisha

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Source: TH

Recently, the government proposed a new broad-gauge railway line from **Tikiri to connect Sijimali and Kutrumali bauxite hills in Odisha,** notified under the **Railways Act, 1989** , to facilitate mining operations in bauxite-rich regions.

- **Location:** The bauxite hills lie in Rayagada and Kalahandi districts, forming part of the **Eastern Ghats,** a discontinuous, eroded mountain range along India's eastern coast.
- **Concerns & Resistance:** The project has faced strong tribal protests over potential livelihood loss, forest diversion, water security issues, and concerns regarding protection of rights in **Fifth Schedule** areas.
- **Ecological Significance** : The region is rich in mineral resources and biodiversity but is ecologically fragile, comprising forested hills, tribal settlements, and river systems, making it highly sensitive to large-scale mining and infrastructure projects.

Bauxite

- Bauxite is the principal ore used for **manufacturing aluminium.**
- It occurs mainly in tertiary deposits and is associated with **laterite rocks,** found extensively on plateaus, hill ranges of peninsular India, and coastal regions.
- Odisha is the largest producer, with major deposits in **Kalahandi, Sambalpur, Bolangir and Koraput;** rich deposits are also found in Lohardaga (Jharkhand).
- Other major producing states include **Gujarat, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh** and Maharashtra, with notable reserves in the Amarkantak plateau of Chhattisgarh.

Read more: **Cancellation of Bauxite Lease**

RBI Eases Rupee NDF Curbs

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Source: ET

Recently, the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** partially **rolled back earlier restrictions on rupee-linked non-deliverable forward (NDF) transactions** after improved market stability and reduced arbitrage risks.

- **Partial Relaxation:** Banks are now permitted to **undertake limited related-party transactions such as cancellation and rollover of existing contracts** , while broader restrictions on forex derivatives remain in place.
  - However, the move is unlikely to significantly affect the spot rupee, as broader global factors such as crude oil prices, geopolitics, and dollar strength continue to drive currency movements.
- **Regulatory Position:** The $100 million cap on net open positions in the onshore market remains unchanged, reflecting a cautious regulatory stance amid global uncertainties.
- **Reason for Earlier Curbs:** The restrictions were imposed due to **heightened forex volatility following West Asia geopolitical tensions and rising arbitrage positions between onshore and offshore markets** .

About Non-Deliverable Forward (NDF)

- A Non-Deliverable Forward is a **cash-settled derivative contract** used to hedge or speculate on currencies where physical delivery is restricted.
- Widely used in offshore markets for currencies like the Indian Rupee, especially by foreign investors.
- NDF markets can create arbitrage opportunities between onshore and offshore foreign-exchange markets.

Read more: **Task Force on Offshore Rupee Markets - Drishti IAS**